Use ChatGPT to Start Getting Mom's Financial House in Order

Four prompts to plan the conversation, list what you already know, see what's scattered or missing, and decide where it will all be kept.

Where you are

Mom manages on her own and nothing is pressing. But her financial information is scattered across accounts, statements, policies, and documents, and you're not sure exactly what she owns or receives each month.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share. Leave out account numbers, Social Security numbers, and passwords. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not decide what counts for Medicaid, whether anyone may qualify, or what to do with money or property. Rules vary by state; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

What you'll have at the end

You've talked with her about it, and you have a one-page starting inventory: what's known, where it's kept, what's missing, and the questions to bring to a professional.

A one-page starting inventory: What we know, Where it's kept, What's missing, and Questions to ask, with who to ask.

Before you start

- A conversation with your parent, or a plan to have one. This is their information.
- A rough list of the accounts, policies, and property you already know about.
- A sense of where the paperwork lives: a drawer, a file box, an email inbox. You don't need to have gone through it yet.

PROMPT 1

Plan the conversation first

WHY THIS MATTERS

These are your parent's finances. Before any list, there's a conversation about why you're asking, who should take part, and what they are comfortable sharing.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A few lines about your parent, who else is in the family, and what makes this conversation easy or hard.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I'd like to help my mother get her financial information organized while there's no rush. Here's a little about our family and how she tends to feel about discussing money:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Help me plan the conversation: how I might explain why I'm asking, who else should be part of it, what I should ask her permission for, and three or four gentle ways to open. Keep it respectful of the fact that these are her finances and her decisions. Don't write anything that pressures her, and don't suggest that anything be transferred or changed.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

An opening you could say out loud, and a clear list of what you're asking permission to do.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Have the conversation before you go further, and note what she agreed to share.

PROMPT 2

List what you already know

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most families know more than they think, just not in one place. Getting it onto one list shows you what you have before you go looking for more.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on her income, accounts, property, and insurance. Leave out account numbers.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother and I are putting together a list of her finances while nothing is urgent. Here is what we know so far:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES, WITHOUT ACCOUNT NUMBERS]
>
> Using only what's written, sort it under these headings: INCOME, CHECKING AND SAVINGS, INVESTMENTS AND RETIREMENT ACCOUNTS, INSURANCE AND ANNUITIES, HOME AND OTHER PROPERTY, DEBTS, REGULAR EXPENSES. Beside each item, note whether we said whose name it is in and where the paperwork is kept. Where a heading is empty, write "nothing listed yet". Don't add anything we didn't mention, don't total anything, and don't comment on what any of it means for Medicaid.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

One list in your own words, with the empty headings showing.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read it through with your mother and correct anything that's off.

PROMPT 3

See what's scattered or missing

WHY THIS MATTERS

The gaps are easier to fill now, while your parent can tell you where things are. The AI's job here is to ask, not to answer.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The list from the second prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is our list of my mother's finances so far:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULT OF PROMPT 2]
>
> Based only on this list, ask us about things families commonly have that aren't on it, such as pensions, CDs, life insurance, annuities, long-term care insurance, health insurance, vehicles, business interests, and jointly owned accounts. Then, for each item we did list, name the documents worth locating: recent statements, policies, deeds and property records, recent tax returns. Phrase everything as a question or as something to locate. Don't assume anything exists.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A short list of questions for your mother and documents to locate.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Go through the questions together, a few at a time. There's no deadline.

PROMPT 4

Decide where it all lives

WHY THIS MATTERS

An inventory only helps if someone can find it when it's needed, and if it stays current.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the second and third prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the list of my mother's financial information and documents:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 2 AND 3]
>
> Give me one page with four headings: WHAT WE KNOW, WHERE IT'S KEPT, WHAT'S MISSING, and QUESTIONS TO ASK. Under the last heading, mark each question with who should answer it: my mother, the bank or insurance company, a Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or not sure. Then list the things our family still needs to settle: who currently manages the finances, who should know where the file is kept, and how often to update it. Don't answer the legal, tax, or Medicaid questions, and don't recommend changing ownership or beneficiaries.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that tells another family member what exists and where to find it.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put a date on it, tell one other person where it is, and agree when to look at it again.

Ready for the next step?

You've made a start on the inventory and you can see what's missing. The planning interview is the next step: answer its questions and it produces a free planning report you can keep and bring to your Medicaid planner.

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